

20 MINUTE MODULE

The Performance Dilemma

BEHAVIOR-FIRST APPROACH

Alex has missed deadlines twice in the last month, and stakeholder feedback is slipping.

You know the first conversation matters—what you say next sets everything in motion.

START SCENARIO



AUDIO ON



CAPTIONS ON



DEADLINE MISSED

Project update was due 2 days ago



STAKEHOLDER FEEDBACK

Concerns about responsiveness and follow-through



ACTION NEEDED

Address before performance continues to decline



Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, you will be able to:



Prepare with Purpose

Plan conversations with clarity and confidence.

Set goals, gather facts, and consider impact.



Navigate Resistance

Recognize and address common reactions with empathy.

Stay calm, listen actively, and keep the conversation on track.



Drive Commitment

Collaborate on clear next steps and expectations.

Build ownership and follow through to sustain performance.

Pre-Conversation Preparation

Check each item to reveal details and build your readiness.

MUST KNOW

- ☐ **Clarify the performance gap**
Be specific about what's not meeting expectations.
- ☐ **Gather objective evidence**
Collect facts, examples, and dates to reference.
- ☐ **Understand past conversations**
Review prior feedback and any agreed action steps.

SHOULD KNOW

- ☐ **Explore possible reasons**
Consider context that may be impacting performance.
- ☐ **Identify desired outcomes**
Define what success looks like moving forward.
- ☐ **Plan support and resources**
Think through training, tools, or coaching that can help.

REFERENCE

- ☐ **Company policies**
Review relevant policies and HR guidelines.
- ☐ **Role expectations**
Check job description and key responsibilities.
- ☐ **Team and project context**
Understand current priorities and deadlines.

Your readiness

3 of 9

33% complete

Check all items to unlock your conversation.

Meet Alex

Thorough preparation builds confidence and sets the stage for a productive conversation.

| Opening the Conversation

Your opening sets the tone. Choose how you'll begin.

YOUR OPENING CHOICE

Let's talk about your performance.

Direct and to the point.

How are things going with your work?

Open-ended and curious.

I need to address a concern.

Signals a problem up front.

FEEDBACK

Best practice

Open with curiosity to invite honest dialogue and lower defensiveness. It builds trust and keeps the conversation collaborative.

IMPACT

- Builds trust
- Encourages openness
- Creates a shared agenda



A man with dark hair and a beard, wearing a dark blue polo shirt, is sitting at a light-colored wooden table. He has a stressed or overwhelmed expression, with furrowed brows and a slightly open mouth. His hands are clasped together on the table. In the background, there is a large window with a view of a city skyline. A speech bubble is overlaid on the right side of the image, containing text attributed to Alex.

Alex says:

“I already have too much on my plate. These expectations aren’t realistic.”

Validate and redirect

Why it works

OPTION 2

Dismiss and defend

Why it's risky

Can increase defensiveness
and frustration

Keeps the focus on
blame instead of
solutions

Select the response you would choose. **Think about the impact.**



Building the Way Forward: Performance Commitment

Structure an actionable, milestone-based agreement.



 Click all milestone cards to inspect review parameters.

 **Day 7
Check-in**

Zero unreported blockers; next milestone delivered on schedule.

 **Day 14
Check-in**

Quality sync with QA lead; defect rate under 2%.

 **Day 30
Review**

Full sprint autonomy restored.

 **AGREED ROOT CAUSE**
QA bottleneck combined with late escalation

 **AGREED FIX**
Daily 5-minute asynchronous Slack blocker check-in

MUTUAL SIGN-OFF
Summary emailed within 2 hours of the meeting

Take the Manager Challenge

The Manager Challenge: Application Under Pressure

The scenario below and choose the best response.

★ +10 pts

What would you do?



Channel

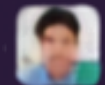
team-general

product-updates

#qa-squad

random

Direct Messages



Alex
x

#qa-squad



Alex 10:14 AM

QA turnaround is slow again.
The sprint milestone might be delayed.



Message #qa-squad



A

Step in immediately and message the QA manager to fix the bottleneck for Alex.

B

Acknowledge early escalation and coach ownership: "Thanks for flagging early, Alex. What is your proposed workaround before we escalate together?"

C

Wait until the deadline passes, then schedule another formal meeting.



TRANSFER SCENARIO

Two weeks later, Alex posts in Slack: QA turnaround is slow again. The sprint milestone might be delayed.

Correct!

Choice B reinforces proactive problem ownership while validating early communication. Intervention directly. Choice A, breeds dependency, while waiting, Choice C, damages team delivery.



Summary Pointers: Key Takeaways!



1. Ground in Facts

Focus on observable dates, deliverables, and impacts – never subjective assumptions



2. Lead with Empathy

Acknowledge legitimate friction and emotional reactions before redirecting to solutions.



3. Maintain Standards

Being supportive does not mean lowering performance expectations.



4. Drive Ownership

Prompt the employee to propose the fix rather than prescribing it yourself.



5. Lock in Checkpoints

Anchor every conversation to specific 7-14-30 day review milestones.

Continue to Wrap-Up

Continue to Wrap-up



Course Completed!



Thank You for Participating!

You have successfully completed the Manager's Guide to Difficult Performance Conversations.



FINAL SCORE

92%

Great work!



LMS STATUS

Module Completed

Your progress has been recorded.



Your Next Step: On-the-Job Action Prompt

Identify one performance issue on your team that you have been postponing. Draft your factual opening statement below:

Type your opening statement here...



Takeaway Resource

Download Job Aid (PDF)

A one-page reference to support your performance conversations.



Save Reflection



Download Job Aid (PDF)

Exit Module ✓